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AGOSTINO STEUCO AND THE DEBATE ON THE DONATION OF CONSTANTINE

*Michele Zanobini,
The Glasgow Academy*

Introductory Remarks

Ah, Constantine! of how much ill was mother,
Not thy conversion, but that marriage dower
Which the first wealthy Father took from thee!
Inferno 19:115–17¹

FEW LITERARY DOCUMENTS exerted the same social, cultural, and political influence as the *Constitutum Constantini*, or the *Donation of Constantine*—the renowned ninth-century treatise that decreed the pope's temporal power over Rome, Italy, and the entire Roman Empire. In spite of the major impact that this document had on Italy's political scenario after the fall of the Empire (476 CE), the authenticity of the

¹ Dante Alighieri, *La Divina Commedia*, I, Ed. Natalino Sapegno, (Florence: La Nuova Italia, 1955).

Constitutum was rebutted by Lorenzo Valla in 1440.² Valla confuted the *Constitutum* by identifying several anachronisms and contradictions both in its form and in its content: his philological approach led him

² On the figure of Lorenzo Valla and his prominent role as philologist in the fifteenth century, a remarkable number of contributions have been published, particularly in modern times. For a general approach to this fundamental scholar, see Luciano Barozzi and Remigio Sabbadini, *Studi sul Panormita e sul Valla* (Florence: Le Monnier, 1891); Jerry H. Bentley, *Politics and Culture in Renaissance Naples* (Princeton: University Press, 1987); Salvatore I. Camporeale, *Lorenzo Valla. Umanesimo, Riforma e Controriforma. Studi e testi* (Rome: Edizioni di Storia e Letteratura, 2002); Mario Fois, *Il pensiero cristiano di Lorenzo Valla nel quadro storico-culturale del suo ambiente* (Rome: Libreria editrice dell'Università Gregoriana, 1969); Eugenio Garin, "Lorenzo Valla e l'Umanesimo" *Lorenzo Valla e l'Umanesimo italiano. Atti del Convegno Internazionale di Studi Umanistici* (Parma, 18–19 Ottobre 1984) ed. Ottavio Besomi and Mariangela Regoliosi (Padua: Antenore, 1986), 1–17; Carlo Ginzburg, *Rapporti di forza. Storia, retorica, prova* (Milan: Feltrinelli Editore, 2000). See also Hanna H. Gray, "Renaissance Humanism: The Pursuit of Eloquence" *Journal of the History of Ideas* 34 (1963): 497–514, and the two brilliant contributions by Mariangela Regoliosi: "Cristianesimo e potere. A margine di un recente studio su *La donazione di Costantino*" *Cristianesimo nella storia. Ricerche storiche, esegetiche, teologiche* 27 (2006): 923–40, and "Lorenzo Valla e la Riforma del XVI secolo" *Studia Philologica Valentina* 10, 7 (2007): 25–45. For Valla's masterpiece, *De falso credita et ementita Constantini donatione declamatio*, the bibliography is even richer. Among the most remarkable works that have been made on this treatise, see Joseph A. Barber, "Lorenzo Valla e la critica attributiva: analisi della *Declamatio* umanistica contro la Donazione di Costantino," *Italienisch* 16 (1986): 56–66; Salvatore I. Camporeale, "Lorenzo Valla e il *De falso credita donatione*: retorica, libertà ed ecclesiologia nel '400" *Memorie domenicane*, 19 (1988): 191–293; and Camporeale, "Lorenzo Valla's *Oratio* on the Pseudo-Donation of Constantine: Dissent and Innovation in Early Renaissance Humanism," *Journal of the History of the Ideas* 57, (1996): 9–26. For a more critical approach to the text see also Mario Conetti, *l'origine del potere legittimo. Spunti polemici contro la donazione di Costantino, da Grazieno a Lorenzo Valla* (Parma: Salvadè, 2004) and Vincenzo De Caprio, "Retorica e ideologia nella *Declamatio* di Lorenzo Valla sulla Donazione di Costantino" *Paragone e Letteratura* 338 (1978): 36–56. For a philologically rigorous reading — brilliantly contextualized in the sociopolitical milieu in which the treatise came to life — see Mariangela Regoliosi, "Tradizione contro verità: Cortesi, Sandei, Mansi e l'Orazione del Valla sulla *Donazione di Costantino*" *MOMUS* 3 (1995): 47–57. The Latin text of the *Constitutum* ("Donation of Constantine") can be found in the critical text edited by Fuhrmann; *Constitutum Constantini* (*Konstantinische Schenkung*), *Text, herausgegeben von Horst Fuhrmann* (Hannover: Hahnsche Buchhandlung, 1968). The same text has also been recently published with a facing English translation by G. W. Bowersock for the Harvard "I Tatti" series (2007).

to affirm that the many barbarisms contained in the *Constitutum* were incontestable proof that such a document could not have been written in the fourth century. His confutation represents not only a milestone in the history of philology, it also declared as illicit any attempt on the papacy's part to claim political authority over Rome or Italy. If the goal of Valla's treatise was essentially political, his *De falso credita et ementita Constantini donatione declamatio* turned out to be much more influential for its philological achievements.³

After 1440, the papacy continued to exert temporal power as if the document had not been refuted, but the authority of the Roman Catholic Church and its legitimacy to rule over Christianity was definitively undermined. Valla's *Declamatio* did not limit the pope's political power, but rather eroded the consensus on which such power was based, thus proving to be a serious threat for the Christian church during the schism known as the Protestant Reformation. As part of the papacy's reaction to the schism of Protestantism, the first strong defense of the *Donation* offered in 1547 was a thorough, systematic, and explicit effort to beat Valla on his own playing field: philology.

This essay intends to analyze Steuco's philological contribution to the tormented issue of the *Constitutum*. After a brief introduction to Steuco, an overview on the two humanists who, before Steuco's treatise, attempted to reestablish the authority of the ninth-century document will be provided. The analysis will then pivot on Steuco's rebuttal of Valla's work — a confutation based on a close reading of older editions of the *Constitutum* that were mostly ignored by Valla and that partly invalidated his philological analysis. The conclusion will also show that Steuco's ultimate goal in publishing his treatise was merely to discredit Valla's argument rather than to restore the authenticity of the *Constitutum*.

³ The first modern edition of Valla's *De falso credita et ementita Constantini donatione declamatio* with the original Latin text, translation, commentary and introduction was published in France: *La Donation de Costantin: Premier titre du pouvoir temporel des Papes*, ed. Alcide Bonneau (Paris: Isidore Liseux Editeur, 1879), and was followed — sixteen years later — by an Italian edition: *La dissertazione di Lorenzo Valla patrizio romano su la falsa e menzognera donazione di Costantino*, ed. Giovanni Vincenti (Naples: Gabriele Stanzola Editore, 1895). While Italian editions of the text flourished in the last century, it is worth mentioning that the first English edition of Valla's rebuttal stems back to the 1920s: *The Treatise of Lorenzo Valla on the Donation of Constantine*, ed. Christopher B. Coleman (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1922).

Biographical Sketches

Guidus Steucus — Latin adaptation of the humanist's baptismal name, Guido Stucchi, also known as Steuco — was born in 1496 to a noble family of the small Umbrian town of Gubbio. In 1513, he entered the convent of San Secondo della Congregazione di San Salvatore where he took the name Augustinus. Steuco soon showed a rare inclination towards classical languages and devoted himself to rhetorical and philosophical studies, without ever losing his focus on theology. He died in March 1548 while returning from Bologna where he attended the Council of Trent (1547). Steuco's philosophical thought has been the object of much scholarly attention, and his 1540 masterpiece, *De perenni philosophia*, is widely considered a milestone of Neoplatonic philosophy.⁴

In his later years, Steuco worked on a second extensive treatise — *Contra Laurentium Vallam, de falsa donatione Constantini libri duo* — and

⁴ Although not yet adequate, there have been a number of recent and remarkable contributions to a thorough knowledge of Agostino Steuco and his literary works. For a general approach to this influential figure, see Filippo Da Cagliari, *Influssi di Agostino Steuco e di Ambrogio Catarino nella explanatio in Genesium di S. Lorenzo di Brindisi* (Rome: Editori Pontifici, 1963). The modern bibliography on Steuco as a philosopher is copious; in this regard, see Giuseppe Saitta, *Il pensiero italiano nell'Umanesimo e nel Rinascimento* (Florence: Sansoni, 1961), 79–82; Charles B. Smith, "Perennial philosophy from A. Steuco to Leibnitz," *Journal of the History of the Ideas* 27 (1966): 502–32; Giovanni Di Napoli, "Il concetto di philosophia perennis di Agostino Steuco," *Filosofia e cultura in Umbria tra Medioevo e Rinascimento. Atti del IV Convegno di Studi Umbri, Gubbio, 22–26 maggio 1966* (1967): 459–60; Giovanni Antonazzi, *Lorenzo Valla e la Donazione di Costantino nel secolo XV con un testo inedito di A. Cortesi* (Rome: Edizioni di Storia e Letteratura, 1950): 7–13; Walter Stephens, "Lo scetticismo nel De perenni philosophia di Agostino Steuco da Gubbio," *Storici, filosofi e cultura umanistica a Gubbio tra Cinque e Seicento. Atti del Convegno di studi tenutisi a Gubbio, 6–8 aprile 1995*. (1999): 189–218; Maria Muccillo, "La prisca theologia nel De perenni philosophia di Agostino Steuco," *Rinascimento* 28 (1988): 41–111; Ronald K. Delph, "From Venetian Visitor to Curial Humanist: The Development of Agostino Steuco's 'Counter'-Reformation Thought," *Renaissance Quarterly* 47 (1994): 102–39. Much less abundant is, on the contrary, the bibliography on Steuco as innovative philologist; Maria T. Graziosi, *Agostino Steuco e il suo "Antivalla."* *Umanesimo umbro. Atti del IX Congresso di Studi Umbri tenutosi in Gubbio, 22–23 settembre 1974* (Perugia: Centro Di Studi Umbri, 1977): 511–24, was only recently followed by the brilliant work by Ronald K. Delph, "Valla Grammaticus, Agostino Steuco and the Donation of Constantine," *Journal of the History of the Ideas* 57 (1996): 55–77.

published it in 1547. Steuco's treatise, however, was not the first attempt to confute Valla: Christian scholars had been trying to discredit Valla's thesis since the second half of the fifteenth century. The history of literary attempts to rehabilitate the *Constitutum Constantini* includes a number of treatises and dialogues by theologians, scholars, and priests who shared a common tendency: they were less interested in disproving Valla's philological approach, but favored instead an explicit accusation of impiety. The reliance on this accusation, however, often reveals an ineffectively hidden admiration for Valla's value as a rhetorician and philologist.⁵ An in-depth analysis of the *quaestio de donatione* throughout the centuries would be misleading here, but a brief overview of the notable contributions by Cortesi and Del Zochol is nonetheless necessary to properly frame Steuco's role within the debate on the authenticity of the *Constitutum*.

Fifteenth-Century Literary Attempts to Confute Valla

Upon his death, in 1474, the Italian scholar and member of the Roman Curia, Alessandro Cortesi, left an unfinished treatise by the title *Folia Antivallae*.⁶ Cortesi's work shows a deep admiration toward Lorenzo Valla's scholarship, but criticizes him as ungrateful toward the Christian church.⁷ From its current condition, it seems as if the *Folia* represented

⁵ The most notable contributions to the debate on the *Donatio* are by Felino Sandei (1444–1503), Giovanni Antonio Sangiorgi (ca. 1509), Niccolò de' Tudeschi (ca. 1445), Alessandro Nievo (ca. 1457), Lauro Quirino (after 1470), Andrea Barbazza (ca. 1479), Ludovico Bolognini (ca. 1508), Iacopo Zeno (1460–81), Johannes de Tritenheim (1462–1516), Johann Eck (1486–1543), Johann Faber (1478–1541), Tiresio Foscari (ca. 1552), Zaccaria from Rovigo (who dedicated his treatise to Giulio de' Medici between 1517 and 1523), Raffaello Maffei (1451–1522), Antonio de Ferrariis (ca. 1517). For a more detailed analysis of the history of the debate see Giovanni Antonazzi, *Lorenzo Valla e la polemica sulla donazione di Costantino*, 105–92.

⁶ Antonio Cortesi's name appears for the first time in a Papal seal dated 23 April, 1446. We know that he worked as secretary for Pope Martinus V and Pope Sixtus IV, and we also know that he died in 1474 from another Papal seal were Sixtus IV given to Niccolò Pandolfini, the *officium scriptoris litterarum apostolicarum*, the post which previously belonged to Cortesi (Giovanni Antonazzi, *Lorenzo Valla*, 122–23).

⁷ "Et cum multorum me moveant obtreactiones, tum vel maxime Laurentii Vallensis hominis quidem literati sed certe parum de republica christiana meriti non

but the beginning of the treatise; the extant text, indeed, does not present an explicit refutation of Valla's thesis.⁸ The author delivers a number of offensive accusations against the Italian humanist, without a systematic analysis to challenge Valla's work.⁹ In Cortesi's opinion, Valla was to be blamed for his impiety rather than for the philological approach he adopted. He is accused of being among the detractors of Christianity, an accusation particularly harsh considering that Valla was appointed as *scriptor* under the papacy of Nicholas V and later as apostolic secretary under Callistus III.¹⁰ Nonetheless, Cortesi's deep admiration of Valla as Latinist and scholar shines throughout his *Folia*.¹¹ Despite his lack of critical approach and philological acumen, Cortesi's work represents the first treatise — of which we have traces — to defend the *Constitutum*. His attempt to reestablish the authority of the document was resumed twenty years later by the Italian humanist Pietro Del Zochol, author of two literary works on the topic — the *Antidotum* and the *Apologia* — both published in 1496.¹² Del Zochol offers the most authoritative pre-Steuco attempt to reaffirm the authenticity of the *Constitutum*. His work follows

ferenda videtur audacia." Alessandro Cortesi, *Folia Antivallae*, fol. 491v, in Giovanni Antonazzi, *Lorenzo Valla*, 195.

⁸ See Antonazzi, *Lorenzo Valla*, 195–206.

⁹ "O praeclarum oratorem, qui quo magis orat, hoc minus id quod vult assequitur, quod autem non vult, id ipsum facile consequitur!" Alessandro Cortesi, *Folia Antivallae*, fol. 495r (200).

¹⁰ "(...) qui(d) tibi venit in mentem, ut eos invehere a quibus magnis affectus fueras beneficiis?" Or, later in the treatise: "Tu ne verbo quidem laesus, laesus dico, immo vero a quibus magnis ornatus fueras fortunis impudenter lacerasti!" Alessandro Cortesi, *Folia Antivallae*, fol. 494v (200).

¹¹ "Quamquam graviter molesteque fero in eum me potissimum incidisse adversarium cuius sim observator literaturae. Quemvis enim potius quam hunc ipsum Laurentium velim fuisse, a quo cum multa de elegantia Latinae linguae didicerim, mihi ipse ignarus viderer nisi scirem quantum necessitudines omnes reipublicae charitas anteiret." Alessandro Cortesi, *Folia Antivallae*, fol. 492r (196–97).

¹² On Pietro Edo (Haedus, Capretto, or Del Zochol), see Gian Giuseppe Liruti, *Notizie della vita ed opere scritte da' letterati del Friuli*, 1 (Venice: Fenzo, 1766), 429–37; Vladimir Zabughin, "Petri Haedi Sacerdotis Portusnaensis Anterotica," *Giornale storico della letteratura italiana* 73 (1919): 313–17; Emanuele Fabbrovich, "Il poema inedito di un friulano dantista del quattrocento," *Annuario del Regio Liceo ginnasio J. Stellini di Udine* (1931): 87–103; F. Fattorello, *Cultura e lettere in Friuli nei secoli XIII e XIV* (Udine: Istituto delle edizioni accademiche, 1934), 80–84; Andrea Benedetti, "Pietro Capretto pordenonese dotto sacerdote e umanista" *Il Noncello* 18 (1962): 3–91; Massimo Miglio, "l'umanista Pietro Edo e la polemica sulla donazione

the *Folia Antivallae* in its two main points: a harsh attack against Valla's alleged shamelessness toward the Church both as a Christian and as a member of the clergy, plus a strong reaffirmation of the papacy's legitimacy to claim temporal power.

Unlike Cortesi, Del Zochol limits the validity of the *Constitutum* to those territories over which the Church actually held political control. When discussing the legitimacy of the pope's temporal power, Del Zochol does not refer to Italy nor to the entire West (as the original document does), but rather to the Lateran palace and to the city alone, underlining the striking disparity between the properties of fifteenth-century Rome and those of the ancient capital of the Roman empire.¹³ The *Antidotum*, an antidote against Valla's lies, hinges on a fundamental point: the Church's inalienable and indisputable right to execute temporal power. The pope exerts his power through an emperor whose authority is legitimate and acceptable as long as it is subordinate to the Church. From this perspective, the author infers, Constantine should not be considered the first *Christian* emperor, but the *first* emperor since his power was legitimized through the sacrament of baptism.¹⁴

The *Apologia* adopts a different form to make similar points. It is structured as a dialogue between Valla himself and Pietrus Haedus (a Latin adaptation of the author's baptismal name) wherein the Friulian humanist examines—point by point—Valla's thesis. Valla's analysis of the *Constitutum* is presented and minutely refuted, but Del Zochol's critique is not

di Costantino," *Bollettino dell'Istituto storico italiano per il Medio Evo* 79 (1968): 167–232.

¹³ "Quare discessurus, cum divina vi potius quam humana duceretur, non modo palatium lateranense, totamque urbem verum etiam quas et antehac Ecclesia Romana possidere consueverat et hoc tempore possidet civitates atque provincias reliquit." Pietro Del Zochol, *Antidotum*, fol. 129v, in Giovanni Antonazzi, *Lorenzo Valla e la polemica sulla donazione di Costantino*, 134. "[Constantinus] quare discessurus, cum divina vi potius quam humana duceretur, non modo palatium lateranense totamque urbem verum etiam quas et antehac ecclesia romana possidere consueverat et hoc tempore possidet civitates atque provincias reliquit." Pietro Del Zochol, *Antidotum*, fol. 129v (234).

¹⁴ "Itaque Constantinus suscepta fide non tam est a Silvestro confirmatus imperator quam denuo creatus, quandoquidem nullum iure fuit imperium ante habitum." Pietro Del Zochol, *Antidotum*, fol. 129v (234).

philological.¹⁵ Similar to the *Antidotum*, the *Apologia* accepts without question a hierocratic model of power. The dialogue aims to discredit Valla as a Christian believer, but its approach — a rigid sentence-by-sentence analysis of Valla's work — highlights the need for a close philological reading of the *Constitutum*. In both his works, Del Zochol accepts Valla's philology as a fundamental aspect of his refutation, but he does not attempt to demolish it. The only philological observation he makes, in order to attack one of Valla's main points, consists of strongly emphasizing the development and transformation of the Latin language throughout the centuries, a theme later elaborated on by Steuco.¹⁶

Del Zochol sees at least some of the linguistic and historical incongruities within the *Constitutum* and doubts the authenticity of that document (*Sive Constantinus donaverit sive non*), but subordinates any concerns about its genuineness to the pope's legitimate right to take back from the emperor what originally — according to the author — belonged to God.¹⁷ For the first time, a man of the clergy implies the need for a strict and accurate analysis of the text itself in order to reaffirm the *Constitutum* as the origin of the papacy's temporal power. Steuco was aware of such need; his *Contra Vallam* inherits Cortesi's disdain toward a priest who tried to demolish the authority of the Church itself, but also further develops Del Zochol's pioneering attempt to build a strong philological defense. The outcome is one of the most involved and passionate attempts to restore the Church's authority.

At the Origins of an Enraged Rebuttal

The socio-cultural milieu in which Steuco composed and published his *Contra Vallam* deeply influenced the drafting of the treatise. In his *De perenni philosophia*, Steuco employed his vast humanistic erudition

¹⁵ Del Zochol's most remarkable point is the discovery of the *letter of Melchisedes* as a forgery. See Giovanni Antonazzi, *Lorenzo Valla*, 136.

¹⁶ "quasi rerum omnium nomina libris antiquorum vel poetarum vel oratorum contineantur, et non plurima sint quorum in usu nos oporteat vernaculam ad linguam proxime accedere, ut campana, ut bombardia, ut molendinum, ut oculare, ut armature partes aliaque permulta." Pietro Del Zochol, *Antidotum*, fol. 104v (137).

¹⁷ "Sive Constantinus donaverit sive non, ego omni de hac re quid opinor quidve sentiam, salvo semper saniore fidelioque iudicio, dicam brevi." Pietro Del Zochol, *Antidotum*, fol. 130 (235).

to link the *prisca theologia* with modern Christianity. Such a literary endeavor, aimed at proving the intrinsic omnipresence of Christian religion throughout the centuries, was imposed by the threat of heretical deviations embodied by the Protestant Reformation. As a man of the Church, Steuco reaffirms the centrality of Christianity just as the papacy found itself forced to convoke a council to contain the spread of Protestantism. The Council of Trent (1545–63), in which Steuco personally participated, anticipates the composition of *Contra Vallam* and demonstrates the author's changing of attitude toward the Reformation.

The submissive and conciliatory language of the *De perenni philosophia* is now abandoned in favor of harsh accusations against the intellectual manifesto of Luther's followers who referred to and used Valla's text. Valla's *De falso credita et ementita Constantini donatione declamatio* indeed attacked the historical premises on which the papacy's political power was based. The rhetorical vehemence employed by Steuco in his *Contra Vallam* is however not only aimed toward the philological rebuttal of *De falso credita et ementita*, it also carries a number of venomous personal accusations against Valla (*caput maledicum*, as Steuco often addresses him) on account of his personal resentment against the Roman Curia.

Before moving to Pavia, in 1429, a still young Valla had tried to find employment within the Roman Curia, but his rigorous defense of Quintilian over Cicero led Antonio Loschi and Poggio Bracciolini, two fervent ciceronian scholars and Papal secretaries at the time, to oppose his hiring.¹⁸ Thus, Steuco attributes the origin of the treatise to the youth's delusion, and he interprets *De falso credita et ementita* as an act of frustration not only against those who were responsible for his unemployment, but also against the Church in its entirety.¹⁹ Valla is therefore guilty from a double perspective: as a scholar whose rebuttal of a famous text proved to be inconsistent and as a Christian believer who tried to undermine the Church's authority.²⁰

¹⁸ Camporeale, *Lorenzo Valla*, 80–108.

¹⁹ "ut si quis ab aliquo igni laesus aut laesus ab Sole, totum ignem et Solem tollendum e mundo persuadere niteretur. . . . Facile igitur effectum est, ut nihil non acerbum in Ecclesiam statueret." Agostino Steuco, *Contra Laurentium Vallam, de falsa donatione Constantini libri duo* (Lugduni: apud Sebastianum Grypium, 1547), 2.

²⁰ "Quid autem de Laurentio romano homine sentire fas est, qui adversus ecclesiam permotus, eam scriptis suis non modo non adiuvere sed perniciem etiam ei quaerere ausus est?" Steuco, *Contra Vallam*, 2.

Agostino Steuco and the New Philology Applied to Valla's Confutation

Throughout his analytical reading of Valla's treatise, Steuco constantly refers to ancient texts presenting older versions of the *Constitutum*, but waits until the beginning of his philological analysis to examine them in detail.²¹ Steuco's discovery and study of Greek versions of the *Constitutum* (*Graecos vetustissimos codices*) represents his major contribution to the issue of the *Donation of Constantine*. The Umbrian humanist seems to have drawn his argument on the compared reading of two Greek canons, α and β.²² His treatise does not cast light on where these texts were found, but Steuco offers an important hint to emphasize how easily a scholar could (and should) read them: "quatuor autem ante oculos palatina bibliotheca sugesserat cum haec scriberentur."²³ An unspecified "Palatine library" had four copies of older versions of the text by the time Steuco wrote his treatise.²⁴ This specific detail is meant to discredit Valla's fame as a learned man.

It is difficult to ascertain why Steuco thought that the texts he worked on were older than the Latin document refuted by Valla. In 1929, Roberto Cessi published a fundamental work on the *Constitutum Constantini* that reconstructed the history (*stemma codicum*) of the famous forgery.²⁵ It seems now reasonable to suppose that the original text was first edited in Latin (A'), but soon translated into Greek, the language of the eastern empire (β'). Unfortunately, none of these texts have survived. The Greek version (β') has been revised twice and altered to include the legend of Pope Sylvester (later included in the *Acta Silvestri*) generating

²¹ "Totumque hoc calumniarum genus contra donationem cognoscitur esse inane, propterea quod profert verba ex donatione, ut apud Canonistas haberentur: nec curavit, aviditate calumniandi proventus, proferre ex Graecis, ut vetustis Latinis codicibus verba ista donationis." Steuco, *Contra Vallam*, 49.

²² The two texts are identified as α and β by Cessi. According to the Italian scholar, Steuco worked on Vat. gr. 1416. See Roberto Cessi, ed., *La donazione di Costantino* (1928; repr. Milan: La vita felice, 2010), 89.

²³ Steuco, *Contra Vallam*, 57.

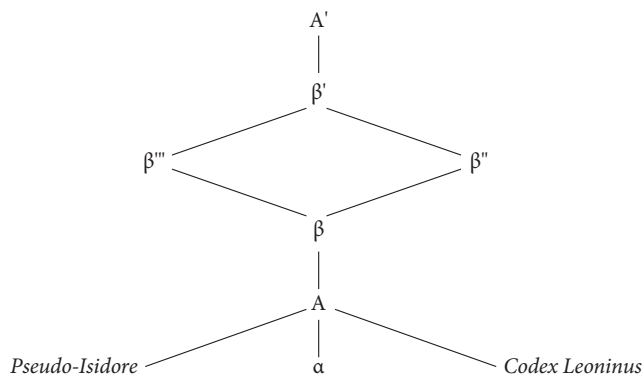
²⁴ It is likely that *Palatine* stands for *Vatican* library. This is indeed the sense of the term *haec* which I don't believe refers to Valla's confutation but rather to Steuco's treatise.

²⁵ The proceedings of the *Adunanza ordinaria del giorno*, 25 November 1928, are now published in Cessi, *La donazione di Costantino*.

two updated versions: β'' , β''' (later included in β , one of the two extant Greek versions). β generated a new Latin translation (A), presenting the *lectio Isidoriana maior* (included in the *Pseudo-Isidore decretals*). From A stemmed three more editions: a text presenting the *lectio Isidoriana minor* (an incomplete text, with only the *confessio*), a Greek copy of the document sent by Pope Leo IX to Michele Cerulario in 1054, and a new Greek translation of A (α), the second Greek text we still have.²⁶

It seems plausible that Valla worked on A, a Latin document included in the twelfth-century *Decretum Gratianii*, a text that ignores the previous versions of the document. Aside from the question — solved by Cessi — of whether or not the original text was written in Latin, the Greek versions are of fundamental importance for the reconstruction of the document's stemma codicum; the Greek manuscript β is indeed older than the Latin text from which Valla drew his argument. Steuco not only found in the Greek canons a document that is older (and thus more trustworthy) than the Latin version, but also ascertained that the Latin version (A) was itself a translation of the Greek text. The discovery of the Greek antecedent allows Steuco to discredit Valla's claims that the Latin text is corrupt. Steuco acknowledges that the Latin text was manipulated, but he interprets these changes as the result of the frequent translations — a true *librorum communis calamitas*, as he calls it, for texts as renown as that of the *Constitutum* — which have been conducted on the treatise itself.²⁷ Being unaware of the existence of Greek texts presenting an older version of the *Constitutum*, Valla looked for a form of linguistic

²⁶ The *Constitutum*'s stemma codicum according to Cessi, *La donazione*, 89:



²⁷ Steuco, *Contra Vallam*, 57.

and rhetorical refinement (*Romanitas*) in a text that was merely a translation. Thus, Steuco ultimately does not dispute Valla's linguistic analysis as, he concludes, all observations would be easily confuted by looking at the Greek text.²⁸

More than a century elapsed between the composition of the *De falso credita et ementita* (1440) and that of the *Contra Vallam* (1547). What truly differentiates the two treatises are the achievements that, in the span of a hundred years, the field of philology had reached thanks largely to the figure of Agnolo Ambrogini (also known by the Latin toponymic, Politianus). Poliziano (1454–94) revolutionized the criteria necessary for approaching a classical text; his new methodology not only consisted of a close and analytical reading of the text, but also included a comparative analysis of all the surviving manuscripts, integral and fragmentary alike. If the goal was to reconstruct a lost text, it behooved a scholar to compare as many *lectiones* as possible in order to follow an objective parameter of analysis. Steuco inherited Poliziano's *collatio codicum* as an analytical tool, and this turned out to be of foremost importance in confuting *De falso credita et ementita*.²⁹

²⁸ "Improbis Laurentiana, quae nullis scriptis eius non occurrit, invehitur in clericos . . . Laurentius . . . tam magis audax ac temerarius quam imperitus, ac supra grammaticum non multum se attollens . . . Ad postremum non est mihi disserendum cum eo super his, quae ait Romae esse fabulosa, quae pro veris habeantur, ut est de Biblia Hieronymi, quae sua ipsius manu credatur scripta . . . Multaque praeterea proponit ab opportunitate ac necessitate longe remota." Steuco, *Contra Vallam*, 78–79.

²⁹ For an overview on the figure of Poliziano and his new philological approach to literary texts (*Nuova Filologia*) see: Francesco Bausi, *Umanesimo a Firenze nell'età di Lorenzo e Poliziano* (Rome: Edizioni di storia e letteratura, 2011); Vittore Branca, *Poliziano e l'umanesimo della parola* (Milan: Einaudi, 1983); Paolo Orvieto, *Poliziano e l'ambiente mediceo* (Rome: Salerno, 2009); Silvia Rizzo, *Ricerche sul Latino umanistico* (Rome: Edizioni di storia e letteratura, 2002); Paolo Viti, "Il Poliziano traduttore" *Humanistica* 6 (2011): 43–49; Paolo Viti, "Poliziano professore a Firenze. Su alcune novità del suo insegnamento" *Umanesimo e Università in Toscana (1300–1600). Atti del Convegno internazionale di Studi (Fiesole-Firenze 25–25 Maggio 2011)* (2011): 349–62.

Steuco's Lack of Interest in the Reconstruction of the *Constitutum's* Stemma Codicum

Steuco contributed to the study of the *Constitutum* by identifying and analyzing Greek texts that chronologically precede the one on which Valla conducted his analysis. Yet, Steuco's ultimate goal was not to demonstrate the authenticity of the document, it was rather to refute its most dangerous opponent. Steuco rightly denies Valla's search for classical Latin within the document, but does not contribute any evidence to prove that the language belonged to the fourth century. He limits himself to trivializing Valla's *liberculum* as the work of a man devastated by a deep anger against the papacy and moved by a desire to defend Alfonso of Aragon's territories from the pope's expansionism.³⁰ No merits are attributed to Valla: Steuco recognizes him as a learned man in the context of the time in which he lived ("eum quidem, ut ferebant tempora, eruditum fuisse")³¹, but his lack of research on more ancient texts strongly limits his influence as a scholar.

At this point a question arises: why is a philological analysis that has been disproven still instrumental in evaluating the *Constitutum* as a forgery? The same work that Valla employed on A should be carried out on the older manuscripts too, in order to determine if the *Constitutum* is truly a forged text. Since the early nineteenth century, Valla has been referred to as the father of modern philology, and his observations on the diachronic evolution of the Latin language represented the sunrise of a new, glorious discipline. Nonetheless, it is also important to note the historical element of his argument. As rightly noticed by Riccardo Fubini, Valla points out the legal impossibility of a Roman emperor donating all his power to the Church, and this is a much stronger attack against the authenticity of the *Constitutum* than any philological proof.³²

³⁰ "[Valla] nihil enim legerat veterum historiarum. Sed audacia tantum, ac temeritate, veluti vento pulsus, venit ad scribendum in favorem Alphonsi, apud quem exulabat, propterea quod in antiquis Imperatorum concessionibus habebatur Calabriam, Siciliamque esse sedis sancti Petri." Steuco, *Contra Vallam*, 97.

³¹ Steuco, *Contra Vallam*, 2.

³² The juridical legitimacy of the *Constitutum* as well as the relationship between Valla's 1440 *De falso credita et ementita Constantini donatione declamatio* and Cusano's 1433 *De concordantia catholica* has been analyzed at length Riccardo Fubini, "Contestazioni quattrocentesche della Donazione di Costantino: Niccolò

Paradoxical as it may seem, Valla achieved much of his fame because of the philological rebuttal of the document; he was, indeed, the first to analyze the *Constitutum* sentence by sentence. But while he succeeds in showing that the Latin text's style cannot be dated back to the times of Constantine, he does not identify any linguistic elements that would help him date the composition of what he considers a forgery.³³ Within the field of linguistic philology, Steuco goes a step further than his opponent, but in terms of historical context and sociopolitical environment, his treatise fails in contradicting Valla. Steuco constantly affirms the authenticity of the *Constitutum* as his starting point, not as something to be demonstrated. His discovery of Greek canons invalidates many of Valla's observations; beyond this, however, Steuco often reinforces his thesis with an assertion of hierocratic doctrine and arguments in favor of the Church's undeniable need to assert temporal power to keep and defend the faith.

In conclusion, the treatise *Contra Vallam* represents a fundamental step in the history of modern philology. Steuco's critical approach brought him to combine Valla's linguistic analysis with a thorough investigation of the history of the text. Building upon the works of Valla, Cortesi, and Del Zochol, Steuco offered to modern philology the first draft of a stemma codicum of the *Constitutum*. He believed that in a time in which the Catholic Church was seriously threatened by the quick spread of the Protestant Reformation, an incontrovertible demonstration that Valla was mistaken and that his *Declamatio* not reliable, was necessary. The unmasking of Valla would indeed have silenced Luther and his supporters.³⁴

Cusano, Lorenzo Valla," *Costantino il Grande. Dall'Antichità all'Umanesimo. Colloquio sul Cristianesimo nel mondo antico*, Macerata, 10–20 dicembre 1990 (1992): 385–431. See also Riccardo Fubini, *l'Umanesimo Italiano e i suoi storici* (Milan: Angeli, 2001): 163–69.

³³ As noted by Giovanni Antonazzi, the presence of the *satrapae*, the *officium dextratoris* and the composition of the senate were clear clues that the forgery belonged to the second half of the ninth century. See *Lorenzo Valla*, 94.

³⁴ The prominent figure of Erasmus, in particular, and his admiration towards Valla (*Reformationis Praesagium*, "Historia literaria Reformationis in honore Jubilaei anno MDCCXVII," *Francofurti et Lipsiae MDCCXVII*, 4–7) was certainly known to Steuco. Even if there is no evidence to support the thesis that Erasmus might have been among the addressees of his treatise, a letter sent by the Dutch humanist to Steuco (dated 1531) testifies to a certain degree of familiarity between

Steuco's single-mindedness in achieving this goal is a fair point of criticism. His pressing need to refute, without appeal, Valla's thesis brought the scholar to direct his philological analysis against Valla rather than toward a more exhaustive study of the *Constitutum's* transmission. Steuco deliberately adopted a *contra personam* approach over a more accurate and thorough exegesis that would help modern scholars cast light on the intricate and convoluted history of the *Constitutum Constantini*.

the two. It is not unlikely that Steuco might have found in Erasmus' letter a starting point for his treatise, a text in which, trying to confute Valla, he attacked Erasmus and the modern deviations from the Roman Church. For more on the relationship between Steuco and Erasmus, and the 1531 letter, see *Erasmi Roterodami Epistolarum floridarum liber unus*, Basileae, "Officina Joannis Hervagii" mense Septembri MDXXXI, 104–12.